

Spacerafts & Spaceshafts

When space travel goes wrong, and you're stranded in outer space, you can only hope that a heavy-booted man with big arms will come to your rescue. Maybe if you hope hard enough...

Do you know how big outer space? It's fricking huge. Some fiery balls with a bunch of emptiness around them. And I was, for some reason, stuck in the empty part. It's just me and my Pal, floating around in the big metal box I call a ship. We've been drifting for about four sleep cycles. After being ejected from the wormhole, on my way to the InterSpaceBase14 to hang out there for a bit before going back to work on Earth, something odd happened. Weird radio waves showed up on the controls, then electrical interferences messed up the ship exactly when I was going through the wormhole. At that moment, I lost all control, there were strong turbulences, I was shaking around the cockpit, My Pal at my side clearly looked panicked. We exited the hole at some point, but I was not where I was supposed to be. All the lights of my ship were turned off, nothing responding. I was off. And so, this has been this way for a while now, four full sleep cycles at least. I've been trying to repair but I can't seem to find where the problem is located. It's getting colder in here; food air and water won't last forever without the recycler working. I had a couple of nuclear batteries hanging around, but it barely helps to keep some light on. I have been working restlessly on trying to repair some form of communication. I've never been good in electronics. A few silicone chips probably burned somewhere; I'd have to replace them. I've unscrewed every panel, and I have been shoulders deep in wires and circuit boards most of the time, trying to find the damn problem. I also tried to connect my bodysuit, which has a personal communication system, to the radio antennas of my ship, to try and amplify my range, but the suit doesn't have enough energy to power them. There is on most ships an emergency communication system that starts to broadcast a message the moment you get a problem, but mine is down too, and I can't get it to work either. Without knowing what happened exactly, it's that much harder to try and do repairs. I can rejoice that my ship wasn't thrown out tumbling and spinning on itself, because I would have been unable to stabilize it. That would have been like being stuck in a washing machine, without an off button.

That's where I'm at today. I'm looking out the windows trying to see if any of the stars are familiar, if I can see a constellation I know. I can see a small galaxy not too far, but I don't think I know it and the rest seems very unknown to me. The ship I'm in is a small cruise ship. I've had it for 5 years, it's my first one. I got it off some guy from a planet with high acidic air, it smelled like hell in it. It took my days of cleaning it before I got the smell of sulfur out of it. It's a good ship, built as a tourist vehicle, to cruise around the systems. It can't go too fast, can't too far, but it's reliable and cheap to keep maintenance. It can be operated solo; I don't have to have a copilot or an expensive AI to help me. The absolute selling point of the ship has been the mechanical gravity floor. I'm not enough of an engineer to understand how it works exactly, but the whole ship is equipped, and I'm delighted that I don't have to float around to go anywhere in it. I kept going back and forth between the cockpit and the main chamber of the ship; it wasn't spacious but it could easily fit five people standing without it being too crowded. When leaving the cockpit at the front, on the right, there's a booth with a table and two benches facing each other. The table is currently covered in screws and wires. On this side of the ship, a nice window is overlooking deepspace. The booth turns into a nice large bed with an expansive gas mattress. Opposite there's a cabinet and a bunch of technical panels and screens. And finally, at the

rear of the ship, there's the storage room, that can occasionally hold fret. I still haven't panicked yet about the situation, it's not desperate. I'll have enough food and water to hold until one of my colleagues notice that I haven't been back to work and try to contact me or contact the authorities, that'll be able to track me. Or so I hope. The nuclear batteries I had help me power some lights, a little bit of warmth when needed, my tools and the instruction manual of the ship, on which I rely entirely to help me out of this predicament. Before going back to the mess that is the cockpit, I fix myself a quick lunch of energy bars, and brandless packets of pureed food, perfect for deep space travel. Chewing on my food, I got distracted by my Pal tugging at my leg. My Pal is a small animal I got off of a planet I was visiting a couple years back. I don't remember what species he is, but he's not big, about the size of a cat but he has three pairs of legs with feet that stick to any surface, gecko style. To keep his balance, he doesn't have a tail, but more like to protuberances on each flank, like fins, if I must compare it to something earthly. His face would be comparable to the face of a lizard, but with a beak, and fur. His hide is pretty soft, but the hair gets stuck to your fingers, like it has microscopic hooks on it. Pal's color goes from a deep grey to a light blue. I found it under one of the benches after leaving the planet he's from. He was so small and scared, I loved him immediately, and as it turns out, he wasn't against living in captivity. For now, he's probing my feet with his tongue, that usually means he's hungry. Thank God, he is not a big eater and we can share the rations that I have. He might start attacking me if there's no food left. Or not. I don't really know. But he's a good companion, we're both solitary creatures, I think that's why we found each other.

I'm getting tired, I think it's time to hit the bed. I remove the mess on the table and let the gas mattress inflate. I finally lay down, turn everything off, and slide into my sleeping bag. I stare outside, through the window. The stars shine bright, and as I look out, I wonder if anyone has noticed my disappearance yet, if anyone is out looking for me. I start to feel lonely, and it's not just the fact that I'm alone, but it also is the fact that I'm in an unknown part of the universe. I feel stranded and lost, with no outside contact, and probably no one looking for me. If I think about it, the only person that might signal my absence would be Tom from work. I think he likes me a little bit too much. He's not the worst, but he's rather uninteresting and he's not the best looking either. But I know that he would notice that I haven't been back to work, and that I don't answer to communications. I don't have a lot of friends, nor family for that matter. I slowly drifted away to sleep thinking about all of that. I had the most peculiar dream that night. I dreamed I was being saved. The hottest man I'd ever seen, his black curly hair, eyes as green as an ammonia gas giant, his muscled body nicely wrapped in his tight bodysuit, huge salient pecs. He came with an expensive ship, docked into mine, and said "I'm here, you're saved". I woke up suddenly before the story could go any further. The pressure of the situation is surely messing my hormones. But the dream gave me an idea, to try and send a message out, in a radius of a hundred Dark Units, which equals to a few thousands of light-years around me. I could try to use the dark particles engine used to do quantic travels at almost infinite speed. I don't use it a lot, it's much more expensive to reload than the regular quantic travel engine, but I can use it not to travel, but send a message that will be broadcasted quite far, almost instantly. I have enough of the dark matter particles to send a message and answer back if I get any answers. But it is not going to be an easy job, because de hatch to access the engine can only be accessed from the outside. I can go to outer space with my bodysuit, but I won't have any oxygen tank, because there's no power in the ship. I'll have to go holding my breath. Very dangerous business. But I know that if I can get it, my plan will most definitely work. I start to study the plan of the ship and organize my little trip outside as carefully as I can. I rarely go in outer space to work on my ship, it can usually wait until I'm at a bay, or at home. I note all the spots where I can attach my carabiners, since I can't power my magnetic boots and gloves. I'll have to do everything manually; I'm trying to remember everything that I will have to do. I have prepared my plan, and I'm ready to go. I make sure my suit is fully hermetic, I put my helmet on, and I move to the airlock,

all the way at the back, at the end of the fret area. Maneuvering the door isn't an easy thing, it's not really meant to be opened and close that way, but I manage. I hope it's tightly close, otherwise I'm screwed, and so is my Pal. I take a deep breath before going.

That's it, I'm opening the door to the outside. I couldn't let the oxygen of the airlock go, so it gushes out when I open the hatch to the outside. I was safely attached to a railing, but I'm still shaken around. I can't lose time, I can hold my breath for about a minute and thirty second, so I have to move fast. I start to move out, attaching my carabiners to the different railings and hooks available, slowly making my way on top of the ship. I made it in 45 seconds. The space is immense above me, millions of lights shining upon me, an unknown sky lighting dimly my environment. I see the small access panel to the engine. Usually, I could have opened it from the control board in the ship, but I had to fumble with a special key to open it up. I'm not very used to be in space, it's not evident how to move accurately. My lungs are starting to hurt. I get the engine to open, I remove another panel. I see the reservoir of dark matter, I take it. My heart is racing faster, it burns in my throat. I place it in one of my pockets. I don't have time to close the engine or get the panel back on. Once I get the reservoir, I rush out, clumsily removing my carabiners. They keep flying around me. My arms feel heavier, I think I even blacked out a little, because I don't really know how long it took to get back to the airlock or remember when I got there but here I am, using the last strength I have to shut down the airlock door, praying that it is closed securely, and open the door to the ship, with cold air waiting to fill my lungs. I remove my helmet as I open the door to the inside. Fortunately, the door has a pressure system that lets in just enough air, restoring a normal pressure without killing me when opening it, all mechanically so I can use it without having to use any form of power. I can finally take a deep breath. I'm left panting on the floor, gripping the container of dark matter. It took me a moment to get back on my feet. I'm grabbing something to eat, then I get to work. It is a very makeshift solution that I'm working on, but it should work. I work on it for a good part of the cycle, and eventually, I manage to find a solution. I think it will work. I must think of a message, short and universal. My bodysuit, which is an expensive model, has a bunch of electronics that'll help me locate myself. I don't know how engineers make it work, but bodysuits nowadays can be powered simply on your nerves and muscles electrical impulses, and they're filled with useful elements. AI, communication, localization, information, health check, resistant to almost everything, from high heats to radiation, insane pressure, and ultra-low temperature. They're running our lives, I couldn't live without mine. It's a second skin, and a second brain. I'm going to use its integrated localization system based on pulsars to find my approximate coordinate and send them with a message of help. I'm using a the most universal coding language that I know to send a message that asks for help. I'm reading it several times to be sure I didn't make any mistake, because I won't have many shots if this goes wrong. I pray on last time and activate the quantic dark matter powered transmitter to send my message. Now I wait. Quantic dark matter travels fast, faster than almost any other particles, so if somebody were to receive it, it should be almost immediate. But answering back could be tricky for whoever receives it. Some might not even be able to answer. I decide to go grab something to eat and then go to sleep. I know I'm supposed to ration energy, but I'm going to leave the transmitter connected to the battery as I'm sleeping, so if I get an answer during the night, I'll hear it.

In the middle of a raunchy dream I was having, again, something woke me and up my Pal was agitated. I jumped out of my bed, my heart pounding, and ran to the communication contraption. And without fail, the little screen is flashing with a short message: Received – Sending Troop. I'm relieved beyond years, and surprised at speed it took for them to answer. I don't exactly know who's coming from where and when. They answered in the same coding language that I used so they could be human, but they could also be other intelligent species. We humans are kind of the rats of the universe reproducing exponentially and just appropriating any livable space without any life to oppose us. But since I don't

know in what exact part of the universe I'm in, or in which universe for that matter. There are about five or six other species that have aligned themselves on communication standards that we have created that I know of, so it could be one of them, and none of which are hostile. And traveling isn't cheap, so even if they were hostile, there's no incentive to come for me. What bugs me a little bit is that it mentions a troop, meaning the army, in some way or another. Let's just say that I don't hate the army, but I'm not a fan either. No matter how far you look back in history, the army has never been on the side of the people. And I have a weapon, depending where they're from, they might take it as a threat. I could hide it anywhere in my ship but I read somewhere that some officers have high energy weapons detectors, so I'm just going to keep it concealed at my waist, and we'll see about that. I was too excited to go back to sleep, so I start to put the mess in my ship back into order. I put the panels back on, hoping that none of what I've done will void my warranty. I get my mattress out of the way, and make some room in the fret area, so that they can dock and come without too much trouble. After some order was restored, I couldn't do anything but pace around the ship. I knew it was a matter of waiting, but I couldn't stay in place. There would probably be a report to fill, so I try to get my story straight, and recall how much time passed since the accident. I try to focus on all the details that I might have forgotten and waited. I ended up dozing off, sitting on the bench, my head against the porthole, when a light pull me out of my sleep. I'm hoping that it's the trooper and not some space debris. It's too certainly too bright to be an asteroid, so I'm hoping for a ship. As it got closer, my hope got confirmed. It is a ship! I'm relieved to finally see some life in the light speckled darkness surrounding me for the past five or six sleep cycle. I follow the ship through the window. It seems to be a human ship, but I can't tell from where. It's a rather standard ship, at least twice as big as mine, but can probably still be manned solo. I see it try to align itself with my ship, trying to align the hatch doors. Now that the ship is close to me, I receive a communication authorization on my suit, and eagerly take it. I hear a voice from a man coming in my ears: "Hello, asking permission to dock on your ship". Obviously, I accept the demand, and go to the back of the ship to welcome the savior. I heard English, but it could be a real time translator, however there was an accent, that there usually isn't with translators. The ship rocks a little bit as he docks. I can hear the mechanism working to lock around the hatch. I hear him again in my ear asking my permission, this time to come on board. I accept, warning him about the pressure difference between his airlock and mine, since mine isn't working properly. I hear the doors open and then footsteps coming. I wait behind my airlock door. I hear him struggle to open him, but I fear that if I try to help him it'll startle him. Finally, the door opens, and I welcome the man in. First up, he looks human to me. He's wearing a Hermes Fleet suit, so it's not the army, it's more of a ranger coalition, keeping certain area safe for travel and study. They're funded both by some governments and some private aggregate. They are scattered in strategic places where they have jurisdictive power on certain parts of outer space and have the power to enforce the different laws. Jurisprudence in parts of space can be complicated when it intersects between different species with different philosophies, lifespans, and systems. The Hermes Fleet's job, from what I understand, is less to police what's happening, but to make sure the areas are respected, and that no illegal activities are taking place and harming the environment. Seeing that uniform relieves me, knowing that he's probably more into making sure that everything is alright rather than to know if it's legal or not to be here and if I'm in order.

As he walked towards me, he removed his helmet, letting blond hair free down to his ears. He had rugged features like a man who has worked a lot, but still pleasant to look at. Brown eyes, light eyebrows, powerful mouth covered by a dense golden mustache, a sandy complexion. He looked around my age, if not a little bit older, or aged by some physical work that he had done. He looked tall, and big, but it might have been the boots, clearly made to walk on soil, and the suit, who was not recent, and so wasn't especially fitted. His suit was worn, it had the sign of the Hermes Fleet on the

torso, a winged star. He had a weapon on his belt, and beside his strong features, he was wearing a smile.

“Hey there fellow, what happened, what are you doing here?” He bombarded me with questions, walking towards me, extending his forearm to greet me. I started to explain to him how I got in that position, the wormhole interference, the ship malfunction, the solutions I tried to find to get out of this situation, and then my last and best attempt to communicate, that seemed to have worked out. As I’m talking, I take him around my ship, showing the vestiges of my adventure. “Wormhole malfunctions are rare, either you were unlucky, or something wrong is happening there. It’s not within the Hermes’ parc, but I’ll send a report to the hierarchy about it. We’ll have to check your travel data to see what’s up, if you have any left.” He moved toward the cockpit, taking in the view, and started to look in the panels to see if he could do anything.

“I can’t see anything right now, I’ll get some tools and a diagnosis pad from my ship, and I’ll look around for a bit if I can get it back and running, if not, we’ll get back to my ship and I’ll tract yours to a base. Where’d you say you were going? ISB14 right? I can take you there, it’s not super far, there’s a Hermes base I can go. You were lucky the hole didn’t send you halfway across the universe, you’re only a couple of galaxies away. If we use a quantic dark matter engine to go back to ISB14, it shouldn’t take too long, what do you say?” I nodded. He was so full of energy, it was a change from the last cycles I’ve been through in complete silence, with only my thoughts and my Pal. He did some back and forth between his ship and mine, carrying tools and whatnot. I was his assistant while he looked at the ship. He clearly more than me about engineering. “I’m not a mecha guy, but I know a couple stuff, don’t expect me to fix it, but I’m cheaper than a repair bay” he said with a wink. He came to the same conclusion than me, about some silicone chips being burned off. With his diagnosis pad he was able to locate one and print a new one on his ship to change it. This simple fix got the current back into the ship. “Awesome, power’s back. That tiny fucker was fried, it’s weird, it would take an absurd amount of electricity to fry it like that. The power’s back, but clearly the propulsion engines are still out, and I know crap about repairing them. We’ll run a diagnosis directly from the control panel of your ship, we’ll take a look at the travel logs, and if then we haven’t found a solution, I’ll tow you to the station, is that all right?” Just like that he takes control of the situation, and I just have to follow along. The ship’s system was taking forever to reboot, and when it did, we could finally start to see what had happened. “The program is running a full diagnosis; it looks like it’s going to take some time. Why don’t you come on my ship, we’ll have a drink, start filing reports and see what we can do in the meantime.” I followed him to his ship, going through the little connecting corridor, linking our two ships like one. On our way, he introduced himself. “Sorry I didn’t tell you my name, I’m Xan. I got carried away, sorry about that. I like when things get done efficiently, I get straight to it.”

His airlock leads directly to the main chamber of his spacecraft. It’s at least three times as big as mine. Everything looks brand new, shining white, chrome metal, and orange light accents. It’s so new it still has that smell, the smell of the factory. There’s a big central console, that can probably be used as a table, there are plush armchairs that just invite you to sit on them. Nice big windows running around the room, giving a nice view. He made me tour the rest of his ship. The cockpit at the front, classic, the main room, where he can still pilot and have a crew of at least six people if needed. There are two small cabins, with two beds in each, and finally, a fret area at the back, which currently had a couple of crates. There’s the Hermes Fleet logo here and there on the walls and equipment, suggesting that this is a company ship. That’s a nice ship, I tell him how I was not expecting that when seeing it from the outside. “I know, they’ve invested a lot in new vehicles and I’m lucky enough to be using one of the latest one they bought.” He invites me to sit down in one of the armchairs, him sitting in the one next to me. “What are you drinking? I feel like you need something alcoholic after what you’ve been through. I always carry my personal stash on the job, just in case” He winked at me while getting a flask out and handing it to me. I smell it and all I can smell for now is alcohol, with a hint of pineapple.

I take a sip, it's strong, like it has aged quite a bit, but not the worst I've tasted. I take another gulp to be polite and hand it back to him. Since I still couldn't place his accent, I decide to ask him where he's from and what he was doing around here to receive my message. "I'm from a Russian colony, in a far off system that you probably haven't heard of, on a very green and lush planet, with high oxygen content, and a deliriant amount of flora. Big mountain and forest guy right here." And he started to laugh, revealing nice clean teeth crowning his pink mouth. "I hear from your accent that you're from Earth, you're an original, you're still living there?"

We talked for a while about our lives, me telling him about life on earth, him about the arduous work required to live on his planet, being only third generation colonist, in an environment still very new on a larger scale. He told how he ended up leaving the field work in his city and enrolled to the Hermes Fleet. At first, he was stationed in his district, on foot around his city, a ranger in his homeland forests. Step by step he got up the hierarchy until they let him manage a small team patrolling a huge area of a galaxy, making sure no illegal mining, dumping, trafficking ore else is happening. That was pure luck that he was travelling where he was and was able to hear my distress signal. He told me it's been tricky to get to locate me precisely and get to me without colliding, or just missing me entirely. But it seems that he's happy to help, and it falls right down into his job description, helping endangered and stranded travelers. We keep on talking until my ship notifies us that the program is done analyzing. We get up, realizing that we have been talking for a long time now. We walked back to the cockpit of my ship, reading the report it gave back; according to it, the ship has been hit by a high energy wave from an unknown source right in the middle of wormhole travelling, ejecting us out of it, leaving us somewhere between the starting point of the hole and the end. I gave me a little bit of information about what happened, but the mystery of the energy wave stays. Along with that info, the diagnosis told us all the major problems my poor ship was facing, preventing it from working, and by the looks of it, expect for a couple of quick repairs, most of the electrical work that had to be done could only be done at a repair shop. Some parts were out of order, and Xan didn't have the equipment to replace or even print it. Now we knew that he had to tow me back to a station. I'm not mad at the situation, It could have been much worse, even the repairs that had to be done won't cost me too much, even if the insurance doesn't pay for it. The costliest thing of this whole adventure was probably the dark matter I used to send my message. Xan invited me back to his ship to fill out the report that we didn't do earlier, too caught up in our conversation. Even though we're not from the same world, and haven't live quite the same way, him and I don't seem that different, I feel like we have a similar philosophy about life. He even made me quite envious about his job, patrolling in space looks like so much fun. I'm on ground most of the time, even though I get to space travel for work, his job feels actually useful. We sat down at the table, and I had to answer a whole bunch of questions about the ordeal.

After spending a few hours with him, and getting to know each other better, I was starting to like this guy. He was nice, good looking, passionate, he saved my life... And I feel like we have a little bit of a connection, like we are on the same wavelength. As I fill up the thing, he's sitting next to me, doing the same. He's so close I can feel the heat radiating from his arm, almost touching mine. We're now done with the paperwork; we're looking at each other.

"So, are you done too? Awesome, I guess now we can finally get going!" He's talking energetically and is grabbing my shoulder as he's talking. "If you can just grab a couple of stuff on your ship and come back here, then we can go." He sends me a list of information and a few objects to go collect back on my ship, he also suggests grabbing some travel essentials and my Pal. "I mean, I just think that you stay on my bridge while we go to ISB14, it's less trouble, less dangerous, and it's going to be more fun, don't you think?" It is impossible to resist his bonhomie smile and firm hand on my shoulder. I execute myself and bring in everything that I would need, and my Pal, from my ship to his. He then explains to me that it's not the best to have our ships attached that way for travel, it's a little bit awkward. "I'm going to put your ship underneath mine and attach it, like a baby on his daddy's belly. It's going to be secure

and protected, right? On last request, is that you come help me out attach some strong hooks between the two ships once they're in place, is that up your alley? " I tell him that's it's no problem for me as long as I have unlimited supply of oxygen. I waited until he aligned the spacecrafts together, and then we were ready to gear up to go in outer space. Helmets on. Oxygen wire plugged. Magnetic boots charged. We're ready to put some hooks out there. It wasn't complicated, I wasn't completely serene, but I knew that he'd have my back if anything happened. Going in outer space always made me tense, so many possible dangers. We hooked the ships without any major problems, Xan is even smiling at me with content. Getting back on the ship, I'm still feeling so stressed that I'm sweating profusely. I have to lower the zipper of my suit a little bit, revealing my neck and the beginning of my chest. Xan imitates me. "Yeah, outer space makes me feel like that, stressful business!" He's so hairy his chest hair is showing even though he barely opened his suit. I'm flustered by the situation; I ask if he wants to drink something cool. I crack open two cans of plant-based sodas. We drink in silent while he initiates the travel on the console. "ISB14 isn't the closest base, but I think that in the end, it would be a waste of time to stop before, rather than to do a long trip. We can't travel too fast, so getting there, with the added weight of your ship will take a couple of cycles, you're in? Not that you have a choice anyway, I'm kidnapping you!" He winked at me his smile drowning in his mustache. I'm not angry at the situation at all. I feel good in his company, and traveling in a much comfortable ship is going to feel like an extra vacation.

"I have to talk to my team, see if everything's alright in my sector, I forgot to show you, but right by the dorms, there's a small wet room, if you wish to freshen up." Wet rooms on ships a usually bad, small, cramped but they're not as bad as the cleaning default of the bodysuits. They do keep us clean, but you don't get that feeling of a warm water shower. Bodysuits make you not stink, but I don't feel clean all the time. While he's in communication with his crew in the main room, I go straight to the wet room. As I expected, it is a tiny room, with an overhead shower and a small sink with a mirror above but at least it's nicely ventilated. I get out of my bodysuit not without effort. I have been wearing it for so long continuously, it feels so liberating to finally remove it. I let it fall on the ground. Watching myself in the mirror, I notice that my skin is very pale. When I get back to Earth, I'm going to soak up some sun naked in my terrasse. I notice some spare hair growing shyly on my chest that I'm going to have to shave later. I step under the shower head and adjust the temperature on hot. It feels amazing. I let it run on my body for a while, completely turning off my brain. I use the mint scented soap to scrub my body, and it is the closer to feeling a breeze that I felt in a long time. I rinse of the soap, staying as long as acceptable under the water, until I resolve myself to leave it. As I turn the water off, and step out of the shower are, I realize that I have nothing to dry myself. I look around to see if there isn't a drying system in the walls, or a towel dispenser. The room is so small I don't have to look long to realize that I have nothing to dry myself. Putting the bodysuit back on while being drenched is not an option. I could stand there, being cold and looking stupid, but it is out of question, so I let my head out of the wet room and call for Xan. I ask him if he could bring me something to dry myself. I feel a little bit embarrassed standing there, hand over my crotch waiting for him to save me once again. He come back and knocks on the door. "I got your towel princess, open up." I slid the door open, just enough to face him. He's standing there, looking at me with a friendly, or maybe mocking smile, a high-density towel in his hands. He hands it over, and as I remove one hand from my crotch, I catch him shamelessly stealing a glimpse over at me. I take the towel apologizing. He's standing there looking at me until I close door. Did he turn the heat on in here or am I just flustered? I can finally dry myself and put the suit back on, although it feels a little bit tight in the crotch after this interaction.

All fresh and clean, I go back to the main room where Xan is sitting in one of the armchairs, ending a communication. "You're coming at the perfect time, I just finished talking with my team, everything is good with them." The low rumble of the ship travelling plus the warmth of the shower made my head feel like cotton. "You look exhausted, listen, we'll eat a bit, and then off to bed, I'm feeling exhausted

too.” He has the same brandless packaged food I have, doesn’t taste great, but perfect for travel. Once we’re done eating, he takes me to a cabin, telling me I could sleep here tonight. “I’ll be in the one next to you, expect if you want to sleep on the bunk above mine, but trust me, you’re not going to love the snoring that goes with it! I’m just joking, anyway, feel free to take possession of this room like you want during the trip. Okay good, night I guess, I’m going to take a quick shower as well, seeing how it seemed to have done you good, and I’ll take advantage of the shower to trim the ‘stache, how about that. See you tomorrow!” I’m sitting on the bottom bed, my Pal climbing up on my lap awkwardly. The stars are moving fast outside the window. I turn the lights off, put let the door slightly open to let the ambient light of the ship in. I close my eyes, listening to the rumble of the ship, and to Xan taking his shower. When I hear the door of the bathroom across my room open, I let an eye slip, only to see Xan with a tiny white towel around his waist. He’s so buff, his huge chest is covered in a nice carpet of light hair, powerful arms, the outline of abs drawing behind his happy trail, leading to a noticeable bulge. My mouth dried instantly. He is still dripping in water, catching the light on every muscle, and leaving wet footsteps behind him as he walks. I even get the chance to see him pass in front of my door opening a second time, holding his electric shaver back to the wet room, this time sharing a nice view of his clearly muscled bottom molded in his wet towel. I can let myself drift away to sleep thinking about that nice view, on the sound of his electric shower trimming his mustache.

I wake up after a sleep cycle of eight hours. I have on the edge of my consciousness a dream about Xan standing by the door of my room, the outline of his body in the light of the corridor casting a shadow on me. I get myself out of bed, the stars still moving fast outside the window. There’s some light coming from the main room, indicating that he was up before me. My head feels fuzzy and heavy, like most morning. I pray that there is fresh juice on this ship. When I get to the main room, he is sitting at the table, with a cup in his hands, reading what I assumed are reports he got during his sleep. He welcomes me with a big smile, visibly happy to see me. “Hey big sleeper, how was your night? I hope I didn’t wake you up this morning, I know you’ve had rough few days, so I let you sleep in.” I reassure him, telling him I didn’t hear a thing. I refrain myself to mention the peculiar dream I had about him. I sit down in front of him, asking for some juice. Thankfully, he has some, but it’s from some fruit I don’t know. I don’t care, it’s fresh and sweet. He tells me about the missions he has been notified on while we both sip our morning juice. I eat a tube of pureed root to get me started. I keep on working on reports I have to do, for work, work the insurance, the bank etc. After a couple of hours of each other working by themselves, Xan suggests that we take a break from administrative work and work out a bit. I look around me, not seeing any sports devices. He’s grinning as he pushed some buttons and the table slid in the ground. The armchairs are pushed against a wall, and lights draw lines on the floor.

“Do you know how to play the palm game, *jeu de paume*?” He pulls out two paddle-bats and a ball, explaining me quickly the rules. I’m not the most athletic, but I’m very competitive, I might not know how to play, but I’m going to play to win. We start to play, bouncing the ball between each other. I need a few minutes to get the hang of it, but rapidly I really get into it and start to go at it at full speed. He seems to like the fact that I’m putting up a fight, he’s smiling in the effort. He has an advantage but I don’t let it get to me. We keep exchanging the ball for a while, until our faces are drenched in sweat. We take a break, drinking electrolyte water. For round two, Xan opens his body suit in half down to his navel, revealing his hairy chest, all the way down to his nicely cut abs, all covered in that soft carpet of blond hair. I imitate him, opening my bodysuit. It does feel better to let some air flow on my body. We resume the game facing each other half naked, ready to beat the other one. Soon, we both have sweat cascading in our eyes, bodies covered in a sheen. The match ends with both of us panting, and a victory for Xan. He gets closer to me, grabs me by the shoulder, straighten me up, stares into my eyes and says with a smile: “You know how to put up a fight, it’s been a while since I’ve had a workout like that, look at me, I’m so drenched my bodysuit couldn’t keep up with the sweat cleaning process, I must stink so bad!” He garbs one of his biceps “Look at them, they’re huge today, thanks for the training, you did

good for someone who didn't know the sport. I don't usually hit the shower two days in a row, but with hairy armpits like mine, the stench gets strong fast, if you know what I mean." He left for the wet room, turning his large back to me. I sit down to catch my breath, because it has been a while for me too since I had done a workout like that, I don't even know how I kept up with him. I hear him undress, I turn my eyes to check, realizing that he hasn't closed the door of the wet room. From where I'm standing, I can't see clearly what is happening inside, I can only glimpse at a piece of his skin, and I can't tell which. But if I were to stand up and go to my cabin, I'd have a better view. I remain seated, getting redder and redder, debating if I should steal a peek. I'm afraid to get caught staring, but I'm thinking that maybe if he let the door opened isn't a complete accident. He was in the shower for barely a minute when the water stopped, and I hear him shout "I'm realizing that there's only so much water for showers in the ship, and that it won't be recycled before tomorrow. If you're not too uncomfortable or shy, we could share the shower, what do you say?" My face must be scarlet red right now, but I will not let this chance of taking a shower with an absolute hunk, with or without sexual innuendo. I stand up and head to the open wet room. He's waiting for me, naked in there. I try not to look insistently at him, but the quick glimpse I have coming in is of powerful legs surmounted by a meaty package in a dense bush of dark blond hair. I quickly let my suit fall on the ground and jump next to him. The room is not big, but we aren't touching either. He never stops smiling. "This is fun, reminds me of school back home." I try not let this situation create bodily responses, but to be honest, this is hard. Being so close to him, I have the full smells of his body hitting me right in the face. He's taller than me, so for the moment, I either have my face right in his chest, or right in his armpits. We keep on showering, our bodies touching a little bit sometimes. This whole situation seems a little bit surreal, but I'm having a good time. We can't leave the shower space at the same time, so I let him go first, checking out his hairy butt on the way out. I let him dry himself before leaving and following the same routine he did. There is no awkwardness between us after the shower, just good companionship, or so I'm feeling. I sit down next to him in an armchair, and we talk as if the whole shower situation didn't happen, as if the sexual tension that is electrifying the air isn't suffocating. Nevertheless, we keep on talking about everything and nothing, but now I can't help myself to see him naked under his bodysuit, and the outline of his muscle are screaming at me to free them from the bound of the clothing. But still, I try to remain calm and friendly, without letting my dirty thoughts reflect on my face. We spend the day chatting, occasionally working, as we get closer from the station, I get some communication back with the people I know, I can finally tell them what happened and why I've been gone so long. The cycle is passing by like that, between chatting, reading, working, eating, the low rumble of the ship accompanying us all the time. When we have both exhausted our to-do list, he invites me to the table to play a game. "It's a card game, and the rules are simple" he then proceeds to explain to me the most intricate game I've ever heard, but I nod at his explanations. "And the winner of each round gets to ask a truth or dare to the other, to create a some competition, fun right ?" Now things are getting interesting, he's giving me a reason to win.

We start the game, and it takes me a moment to fully understand the rules, but as I get into it I start to understand. I still lose the first round, but Xan is nice enough not make me do something insane, he just decides to ask me a simple question, without innuendo. "Are you an only child?" I answer, and we start the next round, this time, we're both determined to win against the other. Cards show up fast on the table, the tension rises. But at the end of the round, he still ends up winning. "Another truth for you, are you currently in a relationship ?" I grin at that question, and tell him that no, I am in fact single at the moment. The game continues. Another heated round, and this time I'm convinced he cheated. But with impassible smile he is assuring me that no, he didn't cheat. Another round for him, another truth for me. "Have you ever had an intercourse with a non-human?" I laugh at that, and tell him that it did happen once, but it was awful. He's laughing with me, telling me that I'd have to tell him all about it later. The game resumes, this time I'm resolved to beat it. I'm getting the hang of it, and as it turns

out, I do win this round. I think for a second about what to ask him as a truth, and ask him about an undeclared fantasy that he has. I think he blushed a little bit before answering: "Tough question, but I'd love to have sex in a very inhospitable place, like a rainforest, a sand or ice desert, that would be so hot. Kind of like it's the end of the world, and it's the last thing to do." I found that more romantic than I thought it would be, I was expecting something raunchier, but I'll take it. We agree to play this round for a dare this time. But once again, he won, not by much. He's fully smiling before telling me the dare he had in mind. "I have such sore legs and feet, how about a five minutes massage to help me unwind?" He finished his proposition with a wink and put up his feet on the table. I stand up and got to it. I start to massage his feet, one after the other, he still has his suit on so it's not very easy to do, but he genuinely seems to appreciate the foot massage so far. I work my way up to his calves, they're big and very firm, it's like massaging a wood block. "I told you I'm tense, but it feels better". I slowly go up to his huge thighs. They're easier to massage than his calves, but they're so large I have to use both my hands on each. I try not to look at his crotch, dangerously close to my hands, and I try not to notice any stirring up there. This massage is clearly a turn on for the both of us, but I'm pretending to be only friendly, and I crack a joke at the sheer size of his legs. When the time's up, he seems content with himself "Well thank you, that felt good, next time you should go harder, really get to the muscle." A new round begins, I am still a little bit fuzzy by what just happened, and so once again I lose. He looked at me for a second, then asks "Describe you last hookup." I roll my eyes at the question to hide my embarrassment. But taken by the game, I describe him the last guy I hooked up with. He was a buff guy, a warehouse guy working on the docks of a station around Earth. He wasn't tall, but he had large hairy arms, and a constant frown on his face, like the whole world was annoying him. He was working on the docks at that moment, I had seen him around a couple times already. I was waiting for a coworker on the docks, but they were late so I was just hanging around. I realized that the guy was looking at me, but since he had that constant scowl, I thought he was angry or something. I went up to him to confront him and tell him that he was being rude, but as he turned out, he was the nicest guy. We talked for a bit, before I realized that he kept touching his bulge, and then I final got it. I don't know if these docks were a cruising spot, but he was definitely cruising for me. Tension rose, and soon enough, I was taking his suit off behind a crate. Turns out he wasn't only hairy on his arms, but hairy all over, and I kind of like that. He was very soft, in the way he undressed me, and rough enough when we got to business. He was well endowed, but not too large, everything happened fast, and we both very much enjoyed it. As I was telling my story, Xan didn't stop smiling. I think he's satisfied with it. "Okay, so you like'em hairy and soft, got it." Last round, the stakes are high. I focus hard on the game I really want to make him go through a dare. We're not playing fast this round, we're both immersed in it, and it's close. The last cards show up, and surprise, I win. I jump out of my chair out of excitement. Now it's my turn to make him suffer a bit. He's waiting for the sentence to fall, gazing at me a grin under his mustache. I stand up and go to the control panel. I lower the lights, and put some music on. I put my armchair in the middle of the room. He looks at me go back and forth, and eventually, I look at him and tell him that now, he's going to do a lap dance for me, as sexy as he can. He burst out laughing but doesn't refuse. I sit down in the chair as he comes over me, moving his hips to the rhythm. He puts his hands on my knees and start dancing. He turns around, making me enjoy and admire his body in its entirety. He climbs up on me and grinds his hips against mine. I have his pumped up chest in my face as waves his body on mine. He stands back up, turns on himself as he unzips his suit a little bit, starting to reveal his chest. He goes around the chair, and puts his arms on my chest, lowering them down to my thighs. I can feel his chest hair rubbing against my head. He goes back around, facing me, this time he is rubbing his ass against my crotch following the beat of the music. It's getting very hot in here. I dare not touch him, I just encourage him. He removes himself from me, and unzips his suit a little lower, this time revealing his stomach down to the beginning of his pubes. I'm mesmerized by the dance, the light softly complementing his skin. I'm using all my strength not to reach out and

touch him, but I feel like my eyes are saying enough. He's ending the little show by taking his arms out of the suit, letting it hang on his hips really low. I can admire his body in all its glory, while he dances and flexes his muscles just for me. I'm surprised he's so into it, I've paid for shows that were far worse than that. He's teasing putting his suit lower, but ends up putting it back home, still very sensually. He goes back to the control panel, looks at me and winks before turning off the music and putting the lights back on. I dare not stand up, so I just clap and whistle to hype him up.

"How did you like the show? I gave it all I had, I hope you got a kick out of it. That was fun, thanks for that, I'm going to eat and then hit the mattress. We'll arrive soon after we wake up, it'll be the end of our little vacation in deep space and I'll be finally rid of your pretty eyes aboard my ship." I still have my head in the fuzzy cloud of his lap dance. I decide to join him to eat a little bit before going to sleep. We laugh at the story I'm telling about a relationship I've had with an alien species, and how awkward it went. We chat for a while, telling each other funny stories about our love life, as the stars pass by behind the windows. After drinking a hot infusion of plants, we're both exhausted, and decide it's time to go to bed. He wishes me a good last night aboard his ship and goes to his room. I do the same, and sit on my bed, my Pal at my side. I lay down thinking about these last few cycles that have spent here, and how I went from stranded in space to enjoying a lap dance by an absolute hunk. I fall asleep to the memory of the hot shower we spent together, making scenarios of how it could have gone had I been bolder. I open my suit all the way down to help me feel myself better, running my hands on my body as if they were his. I'm caressing myself slowly down to my cock that swelled with the thoughts and touches. I think about his hot body, his hands running on my skin, his arms gripping me, his chest against my back. I start to stroke myself, thinking about him laying behind the wall, and I can only dream to join him. I wish he had pinned me against the wall of the shower, and pressed his hips against my ass. My heart is pounding in my chest, sending blood in my system, carrying testosterone all over, my skin electric, my ears ringing.

"Oh, hey I forgot..." I was so absorbed by my thoughts and the scenario I have in mind that I didn't hear Xan knock and open the door. He visibly wanted to tell me something before falling asleep, but he found me jerking off, my suit half opened. He's standing in the door frame, his eyes going from my face to my cock. He's not saying anything. I'm too surprised to hide anything that is going on. At that moment, it feels like time is suspended, the both of us looking at each other, baffled. I open my mouth to say something but he comes in before I have the chance to say anything. At first, he stands next to me. I have not moved, I still have my dick in my hand, throbbing. Then, he crouches next me, running one of his hands on my open chest. He runs it down to my pubes, then up. He plays a little bit with my nipples. He caresses me in silence for a moment, before placing his hand on my neck, grabbing me. I look at him, and as always, he's smiling. He brings my face up and kisses me. It's not a timid kiss, his tongue is soft and runs against mine, probing in my mouth. I feel his moustache against my face. I bring a hand up to touch his hair while we kiss. He breaks it, looks at me and says "It had to finish like that didn't it? And to say that we could have done day from the beginning." He's bringing me up while we kiss. He kisses me on the lips, then on the neck, then on my chest. He's pulling my bodysuit down as he kisses me. Now he's kissing me just above the dick. I bring him back up, take his hand, and lead him to the main room. I put him against the table as I undress him. I still have my suit down to my hips, with my cock now hanging out on the zipper. I remove his all the way down. His cock springs out, proudly up, with a wet tip looking at me. I run my hands over his body, and it feels amazing. I can finally enjoy the candy that has been in front of me. I can't resist the urge to play with his nipples, run them on my tongue, bite them a little. I grab his ass in my hands and play with it while I try to cover all of his chest with my tongue. He lets out soft groans as I play around. I feel his throbbing cock against my body, and I finally take it in my hands. It's warm, and large, probably one of the largest I've seen, which is not surprising when you see the beast that he is. I cup his balls with my other hand as I play with his shaft. It's so smooth, it would be perfect if it didn't curve a little bit on the left. As I'm stroking him

more vigorously he says "Not so fast tomcat, I want this to be long and sexy, so don't get me to excited." He then proceeds to lift me up and puts me on the table. He removes the rest of my suit, now we're both naked in outer space. He plays with my cock a little bit, massage my balls before putting it in his mouth. I let out an audible moan when the warmth of his mouth wrapped around my dick. He's not here to play around. He is making up and down motion with his head, and I can feel his tongue wrapped around my cock as he does. One of his hand is following his mouth as the other one plays with my balls, slowly making his way down to my scrotum. He goes at it for a moment, gracing my dick with soft competent lips. Slowly, he starts to bring my legs up, until he drops my dick, making his way down to my ass with his expert tongue. I end up laying on my back on the table, both my legs up, his mustache tickling my ass as he starts to eat it. He was good on my cock, but he's godly with my ass, his tongue must be as strong as his arms, because I can feel it dart deep inside. He's rimming so nicely I'm feeling my hole loosen up by the minute, I couldn't be more open. Feeling his mustache on my ass is making me so hot. I'm craving him inside me as he's working my hole with his mouth. He stops the rim job, puts my legs back down and kisses me hungrily. Our two fully naked bodies are touching each other, and it is now my turn to head down. I get down to his huge cock that looks even bigger when you're next to it, and I start to lick it. The more I see it the hungrier I get for it. I start to work on his balls, large and firm. I slowly go along the underside of his dick with my tongue until I get to the end, and I start to suck it. At first, I can't even get half of it in my mouth, but as my jaw relaxes, and my throat opens up, I manage to get it entirely in my mouth, deep throating it a couple times. It turns me on so much when I hear him moan deeply when his dick is 9 inch deep in my throat. I'm touching myself while I suck him hard. He pushes my head so I can take it deep, almost choking on it. I'm salivating so much, I love to feel him in me like that, I was craving something like this. I keep sucking him, playing around his cock with my tongue, even throwing some teeth to see how he reacts, until I felt completely satisfied. I stand up, both of our dick in my hands. Since he's taller than me, I get on my tiptoes to put them at the same height and start to rub then together. His shaft is so much bigger than mine it's ridiculous. He kissed me gently, then turned me around with force.

"I can't wait any longer, I need to bury my cock in you, sorry if that's a little brusque, but you're too sexy, you're making my body on fire, I feel like I'm going to explode. I'm vaccinated and I have hormonal protection, so can I go raw?" He's playing with my hole with his index as he he's talking to me. I'm also vaccinated against all possible sexually transmitted illnesses, no I'm good to go raw. The moment I tell him that I'm good to go, I feel his big tip rubbing against my hole; my cock is dripping in precum I'm so turned on. He's pushing gently with his pelvis; I feel it start to enter. He has his hands on my hips gripping me firmly. He's slowly making his way inside me, and I let out a whimper when he finally enters. I feel his cock expand my ass as he makes his way in. I spread my butt cheeks to make room for it. I'm sweating hard, but it feels amazing. He grabs me with both his arms across my chest while pushing the last centimeters in. I scream with pleasure when he's finally fully in, and I can feel his dick pulsing inside of me. He bites my ears and my neck, starts to pull out a bit, and the ramming starts. He starts slow, making sure my hole is comfortable, and makes room for his dick; and slowly, he starts to pound deeper and stronger, my ass clapping against his hips. I'm feeling so full, it's amazing. I beg him to go faster and faster, but after a while, he pulls out laughing: "Calm down a minute I'm going to explode inside in a second if I keep going like that. Let's switch position, I want to look in you eyes while I fuck you hard." He sat down in one of the arm chair, his shaft red and proud. I climb up on him, sitting on his cock; it went back in easily, like it's always been here. I put my hands on his chest, slick with sweat, and I start to make up and down motion with my hips. He grabs me by the neck and kisses me deeply. My cock is hitting his abs at every motion, so he grabs it and start playing with it. When he starts stroking me, I can feel my body responding by clenching my hole, and I think he likes it. In this position, his dick is hitting the right spot, it feels like heaven. I start to jerk off more rapidly, focusing on the back and forth of his cock in me, hitting my spot every time. He plays with my nipples as I close

my eyes, feeling the heat rising inside of me. I'm dripping precum all over his abs. I keep going at it, stroking harder, as I move my hips faster, and faster. I have sweat streaming down my sides, the heat rising from my balls, I feel it now at the base of my dick. I warn him that I'm going to cum, he thrusts his hips stronger. It's coming now, I'm seeing stars and let out a scream while my cock spits out thick cum in spasms. When I open my eyes, I see that I have my left hand buried in his thigh, leaving a red mark behind, but most importantly, I realize how much cum I let out; Xan has a long trail of white semen going from his chin down to his navel. He is smiling all teeth at me, cleans his chin with his finger and wipes it with his mouth. "That was so hot, I'm covered in you, and there's so much." The pressure slowly goes down for me, relieved. Xan is still inside of me; I feel him going a little bit softer. He lifts me up, still inside me, and puts me on my back, on the floor. "I want to finish like this, that's my favorite position." I have my legs up on his shoulders, and he's staring right into my eyes. We haven't wiped him down, so my cum is dripping all over me. Now that we are in another position, I feel him getting slowly harder in me. He resumed the back and forth motion, going deeper than he has so far. Trails of sweat are pouring down from his hair, his arm pits even his chest. I feel his whole body slam against mine, all of his muscle engulfed, he looks huge. He is not smiling anymore, he seems focused, his eyes on me, but not really looking at me. His movement are sharpened, more abrupt, slightly rougher. His chest is contracted, muscles pulled to their max, he's gripping strongly by my shoulders. I don't feel his balls hitting my butt anymore, they must be contracted. All his body is jerking "I'm gonna cum, I'm gonna cum." He's saying the words between his teeth, a scowl on his face. He buries his cock one last time deep in me, and I feel the explosion inside of me, the contraction of his dick. He lets out a loud scream as he is discharging inside of me. He falls down on me, still inside. He is breathing fast, he is burning hot and so wet. We stay like that for a moment, suspended in space and time. His shaft is shrinking, until my ass releases it with a disgusting noise. Under the weight of him, my body starts to feel numb, I tell him that I'm about to suffocate. He peeled back away from me, and now we're both covered in cum and sweat. He helps me getting back on my feet, and kisses me.

"This was one of the best sex I've ever had, your ass feels amazing. You're amazing, and now I'm disgusting. Let's hit the shower, right?" I follow him to the wet room, my legs feeling a little bit numb. Once again we get in the shower together, but this time I don't hesitate to ask for help to clean, and I don't let the opportunity fly to touch him in all the right places. We're both exhausted, after the shower, we don't even have the energy to put the bodysuits back on. He just kisses me, and we go lay in his bed, spooning naked. An alarm wakes us up some time later, it feels good to feel his warmth on my back. We stand up, fully rested, we walk back to the main room to check where we are on our journey, only to find a room filled with the stench of sex, and our suits laying on the floor. We're dressing up while checking the route left. Turns out we are very close to the station, the ship even starts to slow down a little bit in anticipation. Xan looks at me and says "Last night was amazing, I'm so glad I found you, and not just about the sex, you're a cool guy;" We chat as we do our morning routine of a warm brew and a snack. There's no time to do some training this morning, which is not a problem considering how much we did last night. I go back to my room to pack up the few necessities that I had brought and sit back down in the main room to wait for arrival. Xan eclipses in the cockpit, to prepare for the landing at the docks, and communicate with the station. I see it through the window, glowing like a star, showing its multiple ramifications as we get closer. There are a lot of ship coming and going from it, it always looks very crowded. Slowly, Xan maneuvers us to the dock, which is not an easy thing with a second ship attached underneath. When the landing is secured, we gear up, and leave his ship. It's a coming ack to reality moment for me, meaning the end of a very unexpected adventure. We set foot on the docks, I look at him through our helmets, and go for a hug. He holds me tight, my head hitting his chest.

"Here we are sir, I got you back like I said I would. That was a fun few days, but it doesn't have to end right away, how about a drink?"

I follow him to the heart of the station, feeling like it might not be the end of this adventure.